



Radio Formats 101

Radio Types

There are various types of radio providers including the following:

- **Commercial/Terrestrial Radio:** Corporate-owned, large-market stations that are governed by Federal radio/television/communication commissions
- **College Radio:** University/college/campus radio stations
- **Community Radio:** CBC, local independent, small-market stations
- **Internet Radio:** E.g. Sirius XM
- **On-Demand Radio:** E.g. Pandora, Apple Radio, etc.

Commercial Radio Licenses

Though there are many types of radio broadcasters, this is a focus on commercial radio. All commercial radio stations must apply for broadcast licenses from the communications commissions in their respective countries. In Canada, the Canadian Radio and Television Commission (CRTC) governs all broadcast licenses. In the United States, the Federal Communications Commissions (FCC) governs them. Organizations like the CRTC and the FCC decide on the formats and frequencies that each station is allow to operate at.

Radio Formats

A radio "format" classifies the type of music that is played on that station, the overall content and style of the station, and the target audience. Generally, Commercial, Community, Internet and On-Demand Radio Stations all go by these formats. Additionally, Canada has fewer formats than the US, where some are a combination of the US formats (as you'll see below).

US Radio Formats

1. **Top 40 / CHR (Contemporary Hit Radio)**
2. **Urban**
3. **Urban AC (Urban Adult Contemporary)**
4. **Hot AC (Hot Adult Contemporary)**
5. **Top 40**
6. **AC (Adult Contemporary)**
7. **Adult Rock (Triple A - Adult Album Alternative)**
8. **Rock**
9. **Alternative Rock**
10. **Active Rock**
11. **Classic Rock (Not tracked by Mediabase charts due to their nature)**
12. **Country**



13. **Christian**
14. **Regional Mexican**
15. **Spanish Contemporary**
16. **Tropical Latin**
17. **Latin Urban**
18. **Smooth Jazz**

Canada's Radio Formats

1. **Top 40 (Includes Urban, Urban AC, Rhythmic)**
2. **Hot AC**
3. **AC**
4. **Alternative Rock (Includes Modern/Alternative/Rock/Adult/Triple A)**
5. **Active Rock**
6. **Classic Rock (Not tracked by Mediabase charts)**
7. **Country**

What Is Mediabase?

Mediabase is a music industry service that monitors radio station airplay in 180 US and Canadian markets. Mediabase publishes music charts and data based on the most played songs on commercial and satellite radio and provides in-depth analytical tools for radio and record industry professionals.

Radio Formats in Detail

AC

Adult Contemporary (AC) stations play adult oriented popular songs that are hits from other formats. With few exceptions, there is no rap or rock programmed at these stations. Core artists include Michael Buble and Celine Dion but include artists that have crossed over from the Top 40 and Hot AC stations. AC radio stations are usually the first to play Holiday Music, some beginning around Thanksgiving.

Active Rock

Core artists include Nickelback, Three Days Grace, Disturbed, and some Metal by artist such as Metallica and Pantera.

Adult Rock/Triple A Core artists include Death Cab for Cutie, Mumford & Sons, Florence and the Machine.

Alternative/Modern Rock

Core artists include Coldplay, Kings of Leon, Cage the Elephant, Black Keys.

**Classic Rock**

These stations play the Classic Rock hits from the last 25 years. Some new tracks from core artists do get programmed. Led Zeppelin, The Rolling Stones, Bruce Springsteen, Pink Floyd, Metallica and more are featured at these stations.

CHR/Top 40

Contemporary Hit Radio (CHR)/Top 40 stations play the current hits. These stations play the best of Pop, Rhythm, Alternative and more.

Christian

These stations play Christian focused music in a variety of subgenres – rock, adult, country, and rhythmic.

Country

Core artists include Brad Paisley, Lady Antebellum, Carrie Underwood, Miranda Lambert.

Hot AC

These stations play adult hits from artists such as John Mayer, Natasha Bedingfield, and Maroon 5.

Jazz

These stations play music from artists such as Herbie Hancock, Joe Locke, and Norah Jones.

Rock

These stations play current Rock tracks with a mix of recurrent and older Rock tracks. Core artists include Three Days Grace, Seether, Nickelback, Hinder, Billy Talent, Foo Fighters, System of a Down, and Linkin Park. There is overlap with some Active Rock songs.

Urban

Programmers at Hip Hop/R&B/Urban/Rhythmic radio stations across Canada. These stations play artists such as Kanye West, J. Cole, and Chris Brown. (45 Destinations)

Rhythmic

Primarily, these stations play the Urban and Hip-Hop hits, but with a Top 40 presentation and sound. Core artists include Akon, T-Pain, Ciara, Sean Kingston, Wiz Khalifa, T.I., Beyonce, Chris Browne, Ne-Yo.

Urban AC

Urban AC has roots in Soul and Gospel and plays virtually no Rap and Hip-Hop. Core artists include Alicia Keys, Mary J Blige, Jill Scott, Maxwell, MaryMary.